off his turban and flung it at me, and I fell down.'[12]

Another ritual would follow soon. Akbar was ready for his first haircut; to bless the event, he was taken to the riverside shrine of Baba Wali, a popular Sufi saint of Qandahar. The details of the day, he would say later, 'are present before me as in a mirror'.[13]

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While his son experienced such rites of passage, Humayun was acquiring indelible memories of his own. He had set off upon the second leg of his exile with barely forty men (and two women, including Hamida). Their first night was spent upon a snow-covered mountain, eating horse meat boiled in a helmet. Humayun cooked his portion on one of the several campfires they had lit around them, though these were as useful as the burning stars against the bitter cold. 'My very head was frozen,' Humayun would tell his sister, Gulbadan.

It would be almost a year and a half before Humayun returned to Qandahar, but most of this exile – unlike the last – was spent in far greater comfort than its first terrible night. The purported padishah of Hindustan was given sanctuary by the shah of Iran.

Shah Tahmasp, a man of grit and tremendous ego, had ascended to the Persian throne at the age of twelve and would rule for over fifty years. In terms of both career and character no two men could have been more unalike than Tahmasp and Humayun; and the months that Humayun spent in the shah's realm must have been among the most unnerving of his life. Not that Shah Tahmasp did not make his guest welcome; too much so, if anything. In one long letter of instruction to the governor of Herat, detailing reception and travel arrangements for his neighbouring monarch, the shah stipulates 100 horses with golden saddles, 400 suits of velvet and brocade, 500 dishes every day – bread kneaded with milk, marmalades of Mashhad apples and grapes, halva, puddings, molasses, Chinese noodles scented with ambergris, all to be served on 'porcelain, gold, and silver' with sherbets 'cooled with snow and ice'. He orders bazaars in city gardens and entertainments on city streets ('the women will engage in pleasant sayings and doings with the comers and goers'), perfumed bathhouses, plush carpets, tents with brocade within and paisley without – and still the list is